

33 Windows 8 laptops, better try before you buy

The new Windows 8 UI has so far managed to create more foes than fans, and there is a good reason behind that accomplishment. The new UI is more suited for touchscreens and tablet experience rather than a desktop/workstation use. If you have been blindly upgrading to subsequent versions of Windows, Windows 8 will hardly make you feel at home. The learning curve can be steep. Beware.



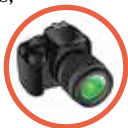
34 Connectivity

Just because a phone has NFC, Bluetooth 4.0, 802.11ac and LTE support doesn't mean that you must have it. The average person barely has access to 3G, let alone LTE and how many times have you transferred a file via Bluetooth or NFC that you so desperately need that feature? Sure, if you do need that feature then there's no question that you must buy a device that supports such a feature, but if you don't, don't bother. Most of it is nothing more than marketing mumbo-jumbo anyway.



35 The myth of the "All-in-One" lens

Many a times, we end up buying a DSLR and then don't want to deal with the "hassle" of changing lenses often. Self-defeating purpose aside, the whole idea of an "all-in-one" lens comes to a grinding halt when you take into account several factors. They have terrible aperture ranges, horribly distort your images at all but a few focal lengths and are generally no better than what you would have got on a bridge camera anyway. Stay away.



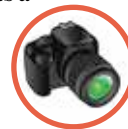
36 4:3 or 16:9

If the myriad screen sizes weren't confusing enough, choosing the right aspect ratio can also be a pain in the neck. Most tablets do come in the widescreen form-factor, but rare ones like the iPad still stick to the standard 4:3 format. The 4:3 format is the ideal resolution for reading and browsing, especially for browsing through photos. 16:9 is ideal for movies and videos. Also, bear in mind that on larger tablets, the 16:9 aspect ratio can be too cumbersome to use.



37 The mysterious X (X zoom factor)

A point of frustration when trying to buy a camera is when salesmen say that a camera is better because it has a better "Zoom" factor (8x is better than 6X?). What they don't tell you (or don't know) is that the X factor is not an indicator of actual magnification but an indicator of the magnification that the lens is capable of from its base magnification.



38 Plastic, metal or glass body?

Smartphones come in all shapes and sizes and also materials. Each type of material has its advantages and you shouldn't dismiss any of them without due consideration. Plastic bodied phones are lighter and the panels are usually less prone to dents and scratches, given their flexibility. On the down side, the phones can feel cheap and might be flimsy to boot. Metal-bodied phones are ideal in terms of thickness and strength. However, very thin metal, as on the iPhone 5 will usually offer no better protection than a plastic bodied phone. Plus, metal looks really ugly when scratched. Glass bodied phones, such as the Nexus 4, while a pleasure to behold, are among the easiest phones to inadvertently damage. Choose wisely.



39 Power users, choose non-reflective screens to avoid eye strain

The move towards reflective, glossy laptop screens by the industry has more to do with covering up crappy TN panels with reflective glass than to hide the low contrast and poor color fidelity. Glossy screens induce reflections and glare that adds strain to your eyes on prolonged use. Apart from the strain, glossy screens suffer from poor visibility in brightly lit and outdoor work environments. Non-reflective, matte screens offer better panel brightness and are easier on the eyes. Of course, many screens, notably those on the MacBooks, come with anti-glare coatings.



40 SIM card doesn't mean that the tablet can make calls

A common mistake people make is to assume that a tablet can make calls as well, despite the fact that you'll look daft with a tablet plastered to your face. The SIM cards only work to provide you with direct internet access and nothing more. There are a handful of tablets that do provide this feature though.



41 Do your apps work on that?

Heavy Instagram user? Avoid BlackBerry, for example. Not all smartphone platforms offer the same selection of apps. You need to identify the apps critical to you, and check if the phone you're going to buy lets you use them. Note that paid apps will have to be re-purchased.

